

Ask Our Bev

The principle. Bev sells towels off a van on Longsight market in Manchester and has never lost an argument in her life. When her mate lost one she should have won, Bev asked Code Overlord for a number anyone can text that tells them what to say back, and its agents built her Ask Our Bev. It worked, so she kept going back to have it built out, twenty pence a go and off her laptop, and because whoever lost to it got it, it climbed from the market to the council to the Government to Number Ten. It shows a woman who has never written code building something the whole country ends up running its arguments through.

Why it is funny. Every rung is the same small thing, somebody losing an argument and Bev's app telling them what to say back, and the only thing that changes is who is losing. The lines never get any cleverer: what works on a woman at a returns desk works on anyone, and nobody in it, Bev least of all, ever finds that strange.

Manchester, a returns desk. Bev's mate Jackie has a coat and a receipt dated the second of March 2028.

"It's not been worn."

Pauline sniffs a sleeve, kindly. "It's just got a bit of somebody in it now, hasn't it."

"Where?"

"All over." She holds out a tin. "Mint?"

Bev. Towels off a van on Longsight market, thirty-four years.

"Would you have won it?"

"I've never lost one."

"I've had a hearse turned round." A pause. "But I can't be at every counter. So I asked Code Overlord."

She typed one sentence with two thumbs.

"I want a number people can text that tells them what to say back. Like I would."

Underneath, Code Overlord got building: four windows, then nine. By Thursday the stall had a card: ASK OUR BEV, a number, askourbev.com.

Jackie texted it, went back, and read Pauline what it said.

"Smell it again."

Pauline sniffs the sleeve. A long pause. "That's me."

Jackie got her money back.

"It lost a few. So every night at half nine, Code Overlord brings me the ones Ask Our Bev lost."

A clamper in a hi-vis, and a woman with the clamp on her Fiesta.

"It's a hundred and ninety [BLEEP] quid! Get back in your [BLEEP] car!"

She reads what Ask Our Bev told her: "Can I speak to your manager?"

"I AM the [BLEEP] manager!"

Half nine. Bev, at the kitchen table.

"No. Tell her to say: sit down, love. You're showing yourself up."

Next morning, the same clumper, another Fiesta, another woman reading it off her phone. He sits down on the kerb and takes the clamp off.

"People kept trying to pay, so I had Code Overlord put a card machine in it."

"What did you settle on?"

"Twenty pence." A pause. "Same as a wee."

Somebody filmed him sat on the kerb and put it on Facebook. It got that busy she had Code Overlord take it off her laptop, and by June it was all over Manchester.

"Then the people behind the counters kept losing. So they got it and all."

Pauline's till: Pauline and a customer, reading off their phones at each other.

"Then the council kept losing to it, so they got it. Then the council won one off the Government, so the Government got it. Then the Chancellor won one off the Prime Minister."

"What about?"

"Biscuits."

"So he got it."

A summit in September. A strongman in a peaked cap, more medals than jacket, is shouting across the table. Nobody has ever won one off him. The Prime Minister tries Ask Our Bev on him, and loses.

Half nine. In Code Overlord, Bev reads it twice.

"Same as the clumper."

Next morning, the private secretary:

"Treasury have signed off the twenty pence, Prime Minister."

The Prime Minister, a northern lad, reads off his phone, the way Jackie did.

"Sit down, love. You're showing yourself up."

A long silence. The strongman sits down.

The Prime Minister checks his phone. "Now go round the table and say sorry."

"Did he?"

Bev: "He hugged Belgium."

The next summer. A white boat the length of the market. On deck, her laptop, and towels off the van, still in the cellophane, price on.

"Code Overlord's been very good. I've not had to raise my voice once."

"What have you done with the money?"

"Nowt."

"Nothing at all?"

"I bought meself a little boat."

"Are you a billionaire?"

"Don't be daft." A pause. "Two."

On the top deck, in Bev's jacuzzi, the strongman, cap still on, and the Prime Minister, laughing till they cry.

End card.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One sentence typed with two thumbs, and terminals opening underneath it. A Ritual at half nine every night, her instruction still showing and the day's losses waiting in it, and her saying out loud what it should have said. A card machine wired into the app. The whole thing moved off her laptop onto a machine somewhere else. Everything Ask Our Bev does to the world, the reply, the twenty pence, the line the Prime Minister reads, is an evening when she asked Code Overlord to wire one more thing in or teach it one more answer. Ask Our Bev is the app her agents built. Code Overlord is where she built it.

Accent. The whole cast is Mancunian, Longsight, Gorton and Levenshulme, the Prime Minister included: he sounds exactly like Bev, and he reads her line the way Jackie read hers. It lives in the words and the grammar, never the spelling: "our Bev", nowt, meself, "and all", "sat on the kerb", "don't be daft". The strongman is heard only shouting under the bleep, and then laughing. The Prime Minister and the strongman are never named and look like nobody real; the strongman's country is never named, shown or flagged.

Three things to decide. Manchester: the film has moved from Gravesend to Manchester, because In Writing is also set in the Medway towns and also climbs to Westminster, and one accent for the whole cast now gives him his northern Prime Minister. Recommendation: keep Manchester. The strongman: unnamed, from nowhere named, heard only in bleeps, in a peaked cap and medals that could belong to anyone. Recommendation: keep him that generic, because a strongman from nowhere lands on everyone and the jacuzzi needs nothing more. The last line: the talking ends on "Two." and cuts straight to the jacuzzi, with her praise of Code Overlord moved just before the money. "I only asked" and her mam finally winning one, about the boiler, stay in the long version. Recommendation: end on "Two.", because the jacuzzi lands hardest straight after the biggest laugh.

Condensed from a longer version, which is kept as the gag bank.